

SOCIAL INFLUENCE CHEAT SHEET

1 CONFORMITY

Useful for essays on: *obedience, minority influence, locus of control*

AO1 — Key Content

Definition	A person changes values/attitudes/behaviour to fit in with the majority group, despite being given no instructions to do so. Key distinction from obedience: conformity involves no explicit order or instruction.
Compliance	• A person changes publicly, not privately • Doesn't genuinely agree with the majority • Just to 'fit in' (e.g. laughing at a joke they don't find funny) • Not long-lasting — reverts once pressure is gone
Internalisation	• A person changes both publicly AND privately • Permanent — a deep 'conversion' of thinking • e.g. adopting a religious belief genuinely
Normative Social Influence (NSI)	• Conforming in order to be liked • Involves compliance • Surveillance from others is needed for NSI to occur
Informational Social Influence (ISI)	• Conforming in order to be right • Involves internalisation • ISI is strongest when: there is ambiguity, there is an emergency, others are deemed to be experts
Spec note	<i>From 2027 exams: AQA only requires compliance and internalisation (not identification). Kelman's "identification" type is no longer assessed.</i>

AO3 — Evaluation

✓ Strength	✗ Weakness
NSI — Support from research • Goldstein (2008) hotel towel experiment: guests told '75% of guests reuse towels' increased reuse by 25% compared to an environmental message — supports NSI	NSI — Individual differences • Janes and Olson (2000): 'nAffiliators' (high need to be liked) are more influenced by NSI than others — so NSI does not apply equally to everyone
ISI — Support from research • PPs exposed to negative views on African Americans showed similar racist views when told the source was an expert — supports ISI and internalisation	ISI — Moderated by task type • ISI has less influence if the task has a physical reality — people can research objective info themselves (e.g. university employment rates), reducing reliance on others

Example PEEL Paragraph

AO3 points to P.E.E.L. as a good evaluation paragraph

P	A weakness of internalisation is that it relies on ISI, and this has been shown to have less influence if the task has a physical reality.
E	This is because people can then conduct their own research on it, such as objectively searching data to see which tech company pays the highest starting salary.
E	This would mean that people can become informed by themselves and make their own decisions, without having to defer to the 'expertise' of others.
L	Thus, internalisation can vary according to the task at hand and a 'one-size-fits-all' generalisation is less credible.

Key Terms & Definitions

Key Term	Definition
Conformity	A person changes their values, attitudes or behaviour to fit in with the majority group, despite being given no instructions to do so.
Compliance	A type of conformity where a person changes publicly, but not privately. Not long-lasting. Reverts once pressure is gone.
Internalisation	A type of conformity where a person changes both publicly and privately. Permanent. A deep conversion of thinking.
Normative Social Influence	Conforming in order to be liked. Involves compliance. Requires surveillance from others to occur.
Informational Social Influence	Conforming in order to be right. Involves internalisation. Strongest when there is ambiguity, an emergency, or others are seen as experts.
nAffiliator	A person with a high need for affiliation (to be liked/accepted). More susceptible to NSI than those less concerned about being liked.
Self-efficacy	A person's belief in their own ability. High self-efficacy reduces susceptibility to ISI, as they feel less pressured by a differing majority viewpoint.